success prompts wild celebrations and failure leads to dark despair.

The point of working hard to recognise and remember the thin line between the great days and the bad days, between getting praised by all and sundry and getting criticised is to even out the roller-coaster ride of being a professional sportsman, to reduce the motion sickness caused by being up, up, up one day and down, down, down the next, to temper extreme reactions, somehow lowering the highs and raising the lows. It is simply a plan to survive the psychological pressures of living and working under a constant spotlight.

The *E* in REPS stands for '*Enhance* key relationships'. There is so little spare time in a professional sporting life and so many people – sponsors, officials and media – all demanding your attention that it becomes very easy to lose sight of the very few people who really matter in your life.

In my world, enhancing key relationships means always making time for my wife and son, for my parents and my brothers, and for my oldest friends, always ensuring they remain the top priority and never allowing myself to become so dazzled by fickle flatterers that I fail to give time and attention to those who need it most.

The *P* stands for '*Prepare* for life after cricket'. Every sportsperson knows that the day will come when either the advancing years or injury will force them to step out of the limelight, to pursue a second career and probably earn considerably less money. This scenario is not a possibility; it's guaranteed. Proactively preparing for life after cricket, through further education or relevant work experience, brings the twin benefits of, first, removing any sense of fear of the future and, second, encouraging self-confidence.

As you start to realise that you can actually be successful at something else other than scoring runs or taking wickets and that you can one day earn a decent living beyond the game, so you start to feel less defined by the numbers that appear after your name on the electronic scoreboard, and so the intense life of playing cricket at the highest level becomes more tolerable, and so you survive a little longer.